Week 8: Classifying with Online Facilities – WorldCat, LC Online Catalogue, and Others

Introduction

The evolution of technology has transformed the traditional methods of library classification and cataloguing. Modern cataloguers now rely on **online facilities and databases** that provide classification numbers, subject headings, and bibliographic details to ensure standardisation and efficiency. These tools simplify the process of assigning call numbers and enhance information sharing among libraries worldwide.

Meaning of Online Classification Facilities

Online classification facilities are **digital platforms or databases** that provide access to bibliographic and classification data. They allow cataloguers to search, retrieve, and copy standard classification numbers (e.g., DDC, LC, or UDC) and subject headings for use in local catalogues.

These facilities help promote **uniformity, speed, and accuracy** in cataloguing and classification.

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Importance of Using Online Facilities in Classification

1. **Enhances accuracy:** Ensures that cataloguers use globally recognised classification numbers.
2. **Saves time and effort:** Reduces manual searching and referencing.
3. **Promotes resource sharing:** Encourages consistency across libraries.
4. **Provides up-to-date information:** Regularly updated to reflect new knowledge areas.
5. **Facilitates cooperative cataloguing:** Allows libraries to copy or adapt existing bibliographic records.

Major Online Classification and Cataloguing Facilities

a. WorldCat (OCLC)

WorldCat is the world's largest online bibliographic database maintained by the **Online Computer Library Center (OCLC)**.
It enables cataloguers to locate bibliographic and classification data for millions of materials.

Features:

1. Contains over 500 million bibliographic records.
2. Provides DDC and LC classification numbers.
3. Allows searching by author, title, ISBN, or subject.
4. Offers MARC records that can be imported into local library systems.
5. Supports cooperative cataloguing among libraries worldwide.

How to Use:

A. Visit https://www.worldcat.org

1. Enter the book's title, author, or ISBN in the search box.
2. View the bibliographic record to obtain the classification number and subject headings.
3. Use the record to guide local cataloguing and classification.

B. Library of Congress Online Catalogue (LC Online Catalogue)

The **Library of Congress Online Catalogue** is a freely accessible database that provides bibliographic and authority records created by the Library of Congress.

Features:

* Accessible via https://catalog.loc.gov.

* Displays LC Classification Numbers and Subject Headings.

* Allows advanced searching by keyword, author, title, or subject.

* Offers MARC display for downloading bibliographic data.

* Provides examples of best cataloguing practices.

How to Use:

1. Go to the LC Online Catalogue website.
2. Search for a title or author.
3. Open the record to view LC Call Numbers, classification data, and subject headings.
4. Apply these details when classifying or cataloguing materials locally.

c. Dewey Services Online (WebDewey)

WebDewey is the online version of the Dewey Decimal Classification (DDC) system, maintained by OCLC.
Itprovides cataloguers with access to the most current DDC schedules and tables.

Features:

* Requires subscription via https://www.oclc.org/dewey.

* Includes an integrated search for numbers, topics, and terms.

* Offers links to related subjects and built numbers.

* Continuously updated to reflect new topics.

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How to Use:

1. Search by topic, keyword, or class number.
2. Select appropriate DDC number from suggested options.
3. Copy classification details for local catalogue entries.

d. Other Useful Online Tools

1. LibraryThing (www.librarything.com) – provides crowd-sourced cataloguing and classification data.

2. Google Books (books.google.com) – sometimes lists classification information within bibliographic records.

3. COPAC/Library Hub Discover (UK) – provides access to major university library records with classification data.

4. Open Library (openlibrary.org) – offers access to bibliographic information with sample call numbers.

Benefits of Online Classification Facilities

1. **Consistency:** Promotes uniform classification across libraries.
2. **Ease of access:** Enables remote cataloguing from any location.
3. **Speed:** Reduces the time spent on manual classification.
4. **Interoperability:** Facilitates data exchange between library systems.
5. **Accuracy:** Minimises human error through reliance on verified sources.

Challenges of Using Online Classification Facilities

1. **Subscription fees:** Some platforms like WebDewey require payment.
2. **Internet dependency:** Requires stable and reliable connectivity.
3. **Copyright restrictions:** Some bibliographic data cannot be freely reused.
4. **Training needs:** Cataloguers must be skilled in online searching and metadata interpretation.

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